

# Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

FRIDAY, JANUARY 2, 2026

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



## THE GREATER OUTDOORS

Starved Rock, Illinois' most popular state park, to receive \$18M in trail upgrades in new year

By Dan Petrella | Chicago Tribune

**T**he new year will bring long-overdue upgrades at Illinois' most popular state park and one of its top tourist destinations outside Chicago.

Preliminary work already is underway at Starved Rock State Park in LaSalle County for an \$18 million project that will include the first major improvements in three decades to a 13-mile trail system that winds through sandstone canyons and bluffs along the Illinois River.

Starved Rock, roughly a 100-mile drive southwest from the Loop, sees more than 2 million visitors per year, many of whom spend their time trekking along the park's wooden boardwalks, bridges and stairways.

"As you might imagine, with that much foot traffic, a lot of deterioration can occur to the trails, to the paths, to the bridges, stairways, boardwalks, retaining walls, all those things that support the trail system," Todd Strole, assistant director of the Illinois Department of Natural Resources, said at a news conference this fall announcing the work. "The last major trail system upgrade to this park was in the 1990s, and a lot of features have seen a lot of wear and tear since that time."

That wear and tear has led to closures of portions of the trail system, which in turn leads some hikers to venture off designated paths, putting themselves at risk, Strole said.

Last year, a 38-year-old man from southwest suburban Oswego fell to his death at the park, and in April, a 37-year-old Tinley Park woman and her 7-year-old son had to be rescued after falling into one of the park's 18 canyons.

Aside from reopening closed sections of the trails and making the system safer and more accessible, the project, much of which is slated for completion in 2026, will help preserve the natural habitat and prevent erosion, officials said.

The park, marking its 115th anniversary in 2026, can protect an ecosystem that supports diverse wildlife and accommodate its millions of annual visitors, "if they're staying on trails," Strole said.

Turn to Park, Page 2

Paris and Brooklyn Garcia, above, look out on the Illinois River from Starved Rock State Park in Oglesby on Dec. 19. The park is marking its 115th anniversary in 2026 with \$18 million in upgrades. **TROY STOLT/FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

### CHICAGO CITY HALL

## Hiring freezes more of a chill

Johnson has hired hundreds since his vow to watch payroll

By Alice Yin  
Chicago Tribune

When Mayor Brandon Johnson faced a long-expected budget deficit this fall, he again turned to a government hiring freeze as a means to save money and show the public that City Hall was taking the problem seriously.

In practice, that "targeted" freeze has proved to be more of a chill, as hundreds of workers were nonetheless brought onto the payroll since the Johnson administration instituted the policy in August, according to city records.

While that follows the pattern of previous hiring freezes under Johnson and his predecessors, a leading mayoral critic nonetheless disapproved of the move when presented with the figures amid tense budget negotiations that only ended the weekend before Christmas.

"Everything with this budget, it's about trust," Ald. Matt O'Shea, 19th, said in November. "I don't believe the math that they've come up with ... and now to find out that they've hired (hundreds of) non-public-safety positions while we were in a hiring freeze? This is nothing but a shell game with them."

Some financial experts stress that it's unrealistic for local government to maintain the same level of services without new hires, even if police and fire are excluded. To that end,

Turn to Freeze, Page 2

### CHICAGO SPORTS



CHRIS SWEDA/TRIBUNE

## Bears' fate rests on the defense

Feel-good buzz will be difficult to carry into the playoffs if the Bears cannot right much of what went wrong defensively against a peaking 49ers offense they may soon face again.

## Dozens dead as fire rips through Swiss resort

By Jamey Keaten,  
Stefanie Dazio  
and John Leicester  
Associated Press

CRANS-MONTANA, Switzerland — About 40 people were killed and another 115 injured, most of them seriously, after a fire ripped through a bar's New Year celebration in a Swiss Alpine

resort less than two hours after midnight Thursday, police said. Authorities did not immediately have an exact count of the deceased.

The Crans-Montana resort is best known as an international ski and golf venue, and overnight, its crowded Le Constellation bar morphed from a scene of revelry into the site of potentially one of

Switzerland's worst tragedies.

The country will hold five days of mourning.

Valais Canton police commander Frédéric Gisler said during a news conference that work is underway to identify the victims and inform their families, adding that the community is "devastated."

The authorities said that given

the popularity of the town as a tourist destination, foreign nationals were likely to be among them.

"Significant resources have been deployed from a forensic medicine perspective, primarily to identify the victims," said Beatrice Pilloud, prosecutor general of the

Turn to Fire, Page 4

## Burke's remade court ushers in '26

Immigration protests, trial of man charged in judge's death among cases to watch in new year

By Madeline Buckley  
Chicago Tribune

In 2025, Cook County began the year with a new state's attorney and ended it with a new chief judge, ushering in another era for one of the largest court systems in the country.

Upon taking office in December 2024, State's Attorney Eileen O'Neill Burke implemented policy changes that were cheered and criticized, including order-

ing prosecutors to automatically seek pretrial detention in certain circumstances and allowing police officers to bypass the office's felony review process in some low-level gun-related felony cases.

By the end of the year, former Chief Judge Tim Evans' nearly quarter-century reign heading the Cook County judiciary was ended when Judge Charles Beach defeated him in a secret-ballot election.

Evans' historic eight terms as

the first Black chief judge saw the county through reforms, changes and upheavals including the elimination of cash bail and the COVID-19 pandemic.

Well-liked among his judicial colleagues, Beach has pledged to improve communication among court stakeholders and increase transparency.

He takes the reins at a time when the court system faces a number of challenges, with his office overseeing the often-troubled Juvenile Temporary Detention Center and absorbing

Turn to Court, Page 4



Cook County State's Attorney Eileen O'Neill Burke speaks about Micheal Ward's case in Chicago on March 11. Ward, accused in a 2013 shooting, will be retried this year. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

TODAY'S  
WEATHER



High 26 Low 19

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 10

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere  
178th year No. 2 © Chicago Tribune

